

not make your collaboration financial? After all, you're partners. The more you have invested in staying together—figuratively and financially—the harder it will be to separate. This doesn't minimize your marriage; it actually helps strengthen it. And it doesn't mean you are dependent or codependent; what you're trying to establish is *interdependence*, where you both have equal but separate financial identities. If you structure your partnership in this way, you'll honor your commitment to one another by focusing on what really matters: finding lasting financial freedom.

I started this chapter by telling you about Katrina, who, two years later, is still trying to dig herself and her children out of debt. I'd like to end it by telling you a very different tale: the story of a woman I met on *Dragons' Den* who is the polar opposite of disenfranchised.

Esther emigrated from China 15 years ago with her husband, Ed. She's always had a head for numbers. In fact, the couple decided early on that Esther would handle the family finances, because even Ed knew she was far better with money than he was. It was Esther who started the arduous process of applying to immigrate to Canada while she and Ed were living in Shanghai, and thanks to her diligence, their move to Canada was eventually approved.

They met the challenge with gusto, working a variety of jobs—most of which they were overqualified for—to save money. Their work ethic was tremendous, and they made many personal sacrifices to amass a bit of cash, including living in a one-room apartment. Esther counted every penny going in and every penny going out. In six months, they had paid off the loan they had taken out to finance their move. Six months after that, the couple had accrued a small nest egg. Esther watched with pleasure as the money in their accounts began to grow.

That's right: *accounts*. Plural. Esther had always had her own money. She had brought it from China, and as soon as she and Ed arrived in Canada, she wasted no time setting up her own account. There was the joint account she shared with Ed, of course, which she monitored closely, but 10 percent of the money she earned went into a separate account that was hers alone. As their savings grew,